

Building on a heritage of more than a hundred years of voice communications excellence, Siemens Enterprise Communications is one of the global leaders in unified communication solutions. It provides comprehensive communication and collaboration solutions for organisations of all sizes.

Anil Kumar Jain, managing director of the Indian entity of Siemens Enterprise Communications, also heads the company's sales operations for the Asia Pacific region. Recently, he spoke to Uma Bansal, executive editor at EFY, about the changing landscape of enterprise communications. Excerpts:

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“Unified communications is going to become a key competitive advantage”

What are the key considerations for successful deployment of a communication solution?

Communication solutions deployment has taken a different shape over the years. Till now, it was a premises-based, hardware-centric model. But now it is slowly changing to a hosted-services, software-centric model.

Some important criteria while deciding about a communication solution are open standards (no lock-in to a specific vendor or technology), high availability, disaster recovery, integral security, intuitive easy-to-use user interfaces, Web-based centralised management and green communication (low energy consumption).

What concerns surface in today's extended business environment including remote and mobile workers?

Remote and mobile employees demand the same set of services as they get when working from the office. There are different sets of challenges when including such mobile workers in enterprise communications.

The biggest challenge is security. As remote employees

use public networks like the Internet, there has to be a secure mechanism to authenticate such employees.

The second challenge is proliferation of smartphones in enterprises. All these devices should be treated as mini laptops and managed from security as well as processes perspective in case the device is lost. Enterprises today need a mobile device management solution to handle these challenges.

How are mobile and fixed communication services being converged?

In the past, fixed and mobile networks were separate islands with very basic interconnectivity. Today's information workers demand always-on connectivity irrespective of their location. Latest technologies like fixed-mobile convergence are trying to address this subject.

In fixed-mobile convergence, the user can easily migrate between corporate wireless local-area network (LAN) and public GSM/3G network without any disconnection of calls. This is creating new opportunities both for enterprises as